▼ PRABHA MALLIKARJUN, *48*

| CONGRESS | *Davanagere, Karnataka*



A dental surgeon from the Bapuji Dental College, Prabha married into the family that ran the 66-year-old Bapuji Educational Association, which has over 47 schools, colleges and healthcare facilities in Davanagere. Soon, she not only found herself organising health screening camps and skill development through the SS Care Trust, but also participating in the family's political campaigns. Her father-in-law Shamanur Shivashankarappa, 93, is the Congress MLA from Davanagere South while her husband S.S. Mallikarjun represents Davanagere North. It was only a matter of time before Prabha took the electoral plunge herself. Pitted against another woman, Gayathri Siddeshwara of the BJP, Prabha edged past by a mere 26,000-odd votes to wrest a seat that her party had not won since 1999.

► SHARMILA SARKAR, *45*

| TMC | *Bardhaman Purba (SC), West Bengal*



Psychiatrist Sharmila Sarkar had never envisioned a career in politics until March, when a phone call from her elder sister—a TMC worker—changed everything. She was asked to contest the LS poll. "I was hesitant in the beginning. But then I thought that since my job is to heal the minds of people, let me try doing it as their parliamentarian," says the former faculty member at the Calcutta National Medical College and Hospital, who is married to Dr Sudip Kumar Ghosh, who heads the dermatology department at R.G. Kar Medical College and Hospital in Kolkata.



◄ KALGE SHIVAJI BANDAPPA, *55*

| CONGRESS | *Latur (SC), Maharashtra*

The ophthalmologist is believed to have had his eye on the Latur Lok Sabha constituency ever since 2009 when it was reserved for the Scheduled Castes. However, Kalge—a Lingayat from the Mala Jangam caste—could only emerge as a contender for the seat three elections later. The Grand Old Party has won the constituency a remarkable 11 times, but had lost it to the BJP. Kalge has now brought back honour, and the seat, back to them.

An alumnus of the MGM Medical College, Indore, Mishra traded his dental tools for the political spotlight when he left his government service as a dentist. His first foray into politics came in 2008, when he ran unsuccessfully in the assembly election as a BSP candidate. Undeterred, he later joined the BJP. Mishra's private nursing home in Sidhi is now run by his son, also a doctor. His two daughters are also dentists, while his wife is a medical practitioner, making theirs a truly family affair. Mishra's own thirst for knowledge is insatiable, as he added an MA in Political Science from the Indira Gandhi National Open University two years back to his qualifications.

► RAJESH MISHRA, *66*

| BJP | Sidhi, Madhya Pradesh

